

Tooling Guide

What we used, the comparable alternatives, real CRMs to graduate to, and the complementary tools that round out the stack.

The demo runs on three layers. You can swap any one of them for a comparable tool, graduate to a dedicated CRM when you outgrow Notion, and bolt on complementary tools as you grow. This guide helps you choose without analysis paralysis.

Layer	What it does	We used
Data / Workspace	The system of record — your CRM, projects, tasks, docs	Notion
Automation	The engine that connects tools and runs workflows	n8n
Intelligence	The AI that reads, scores, writes, and decides	Claude

ALTERNATIVES

Comparable tools

Data / Workspace — instead of Notion

Tool	Best when...	Trade-off
Airtable	You think in spreadsheets and need powerful relational data + a strong API	Weaker as a docs/wiki; can get pricey per-seat
Coda	You want docs + tables + buttons/automation in one, very flexible	Steeper learning curve; smaller ecosystem
ClickUp	Project/task management is your center of gravity	Feature-dense; can feel heavy for a CRM
Microsoft Loop / Lists	You live in the Microsoft 365 ecosystem	Automation and API maturity still catching up

Why Notion for the demo: docs, databases, relations, and buttons in one place, a clean API, and a low barrier for non-technical teams to actually maintain it.

Automation — instead of n8n

Tool	Best when...	Trade-off
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Make (Integromat)	You want a visual builder with lots of pre-built app modules	Operation-based pricing can scale unexpectedly
Zapier	You want the simplest "when this, do that," huge app catalog	Pricier at volume; less flexible for branching/code
Pipedream	You're developer-leaning and love dropping in code steps	More technical; less of a visual canvas
Workato / Power Automate	Enterprise governance, SSO, and IT controls matter	Heavier, costlier, slower to start

Why n8n for the demo: self-hostable, predictable pricing, a real code node when you need it, and you own your data and workflows. Comfortably handles "Run" and scales toward "Fly".

Intelligence — instead of Claude

Tool	Best when...	Trade-off
OpenAI (GPT)	You want the broadest tooling/ecosystem and function-calling maturity	Behavior and pricing vary by model tier
Google Gemini	You're in Google Workspace or need very long context / multimodal	Ecosystem still maturing for automation
Open-weight (Llama, Mistral, Qwen)	You need on-prem / private data, or want to control cost at scale	You run the infra; more setup and tuning

Why Claude for the demo: strong instruction-following and reliable structured (JSON) output — exactly what you need when an AI step writes straight into your database.

GRADUATE Real CRMs

Notion is a capable lightweight CRM — perfect for getting to "Run." But a dedicated CRM earns its keep once you need any of these: high-volume pipeline with built-in automation, native email/calendar sync and open/click tracking, call & SMS tooling, real forecasting and reporting dashboards, or several reps with roles and permissions. The good news: every CRM below connects to n8n, so the rest of your stack keeps working.

CRM	Best for...	Trade-off
HubSpot	Inbound-led teams that want CRM + marketing + service in one, starting on a generous free tier	Costs climb as you add Hubs and contacts; can become a lot of tool
Pipedrive	Small sales teams that want a clean, visual pipeline and fast setup	Lighter on marketing and support features

Close	Outbound / inside sales that live in calls, SMS, and email sequences	Less suited to marketing or complex post-sale workflows
Folk	Agencies and relationship-driven teams wanting a modern, Notion-like feel with email tools	Newer; smaller ecosystem and integrations
Attio	Data-savvy teams that want a flexible, highly customizable, modern CRM	Newer platform; you design more of it yourself
Copper	Teams that run on Google Workspace and want CRM inside Gmail	Best value only if you're Google-native
Zoho CRM	Budget-conscious teams wanting a broad, affordable all-in-one suite (Zoho One)	UI can feel dated; depth varies by module
Freshsales	Teams wanting built-in phone, AI scoring, and good support tooling at a fair price	Smaller ecosystem than HubSpot/Salesforce
Salesforce	Larger orgs needing deep customization, governance, and a vast app marketplace	Expensive and complex; usually overkill for small teams

How to choose a CRM — match it to your motion: inbound & content → **HubSpot**; simple visual pipeline → **Pipedrive**; heavy calling/outbound → **Close**; Google-native → **Copper**; agency / relationships → **Folk or Attio**; enterprise → **Salesforce**. And even after you move the CRM out, keep **Notion** for projects, tasks, and SOPs — they don't need to live in the CRM.

ADD-ONS Complementary tools

These plug into the stack to extend it. Most connect to n8n with a node or a webhook.

Function	Tools	Where it fits
Scheduling	Calendly, Cal.com	Embed a booking link in onboarding emails (the "Jog" win)
Forms	Tally, Fillout, Typeform	Capture leads if you don't want to hand-code a form
Payments & invoicing	Stripe, QuickBooks, Wave	Trigger an invoice when a client is onboarded
E-signature	DocuSign, Dropbox Sign	Kick off onboarding when a contract is signed
Transactional email	SMTP, Resend, Postmark, Gmail	Send the welcome / wrap-up emails reliably
Team alerts	Slack, Discord	Ping the team on a high-priority lead (and the bonus demo)
Docs & storage	Google Drive, Notion	Project assets and the document repos of "Run"

How to choose

- **Start with the job, not the tool.** Name the process you're fixing (the SOP), then pick the smallest tool that does it well.
- **Optimize for who maintains it.** The best tool is the one your team will actually keep up to date.
- **Watch usage-based pricing.** Per-operation and per-task plans (Zapier, Make) can surprise you at volume — model your monthly run count first.
- **Don't graduate too early.** Notion-as-CRM is fine until a real constraint forces the move. Migrate when the pain is specific, not aspirational.
- **Avoid lock-in early.** Favor tools with exports and an API so you can move as you mature from Run toward Fly.
- **De-risk with the smallest test.** Before you commit, run one real workflow end to end on a free tier.

Rule of thumb: keep one tool per layer (data, automation, intelligence), graduate the CRM only when a real constraint demands it, and add complementary tools one process at a time. A simple stack you trust beats a clever stack you don't.